

Why Systems Keep Solving Yesterday's Problems

Temporal Drift, Institutional Lag, and Delayed Correction

Reality Drift Framework — Taxonomy Note #8

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The Basic Pattern

Systems are usually built in response to real conditions.

A policy addresses a visible problem.

A workflow reflects a known constraint.

A metric captures what once mattered.

The world then changes.

The system often does not.

The core sequence is:

changing reality → inherited model → delayed correction → obsolete response → temporal drift

What Is Temporal Drift?

Temporal Drift is the growing gap between current reality and the older conditions a system still assumes.

The system may continue functioning exactly as designed.

Its procedures may remain consistent.

Its metrics may remain stable.

Its response may simply belong to an earlier world.

How the Gap Widens

A system begins with direct contact.

Its rules are shaped by current conditions.

Over time, those rules become embedded in software, policy, staffing, budgets, incentives, and institutional memory.

Reality continues changing.

The model changes more slowly.

Eventually, the system is no longer responding to the world in front of it.

It is responding to a preserved representation of the past.

Before, During, and After

Before

The model and reality are closely aligned.

The response fits the conditions that produced it.

During

Reality shifts gradually.

New conditions appear, but the old system remains workable enough to survive.

After

The inherited response becomes visibly mismatched.

The system appears irrational only because its original logic has been separated from the time in which that logic made sense.

Why Correction Is Delayed

Correction is expensive.

Changing a system means revising procedures, retraining people, replacing software, reallocating resources, and admitting that established assumptions are obsolete.

Delay therefore feels safer than revision.

The old model survives because it remains legible, familiar, and institutionally supported.

The new reality remains harder to formalize.

Temporal Drift and Reality Drift

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, Temporal Drift occurs when a system remains answerable to an older representation of reality after the underlying conditions have changed.

The policy may still be enforced.

The metric may still be reported.

The process may still be completed.

The system remains coherent.

It is simply coherent with the past.

Temporal Drift begins when the rate of change in reality exceeds the rate of correction in the system.

The Core Principle

Many systems are not failing because they have no logic.

They are failing because they are still applying yesterday's logic to today's conditions.

The model survives.

The world moves on.

Temporal Drift is what happens when reality updates faster than the systems built to represent it.

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